Chunnu Pathak, who supplements farming income with contractor work, says, "You can't deny the good work the BJP has done, like medical college hospitals in every district, though local corruption is even more than under the Congress." The real Brahmin bugbear is different: the Thakur mafia, especially under local don Brijesh Singh. They control everything here: from public works tenders to that biggest money-spinner, mining.

Past picture-postcard miles of sheesham, sal, tendu—even the tree cover has central Indian traits—Gond village Babbandiha has a more basic plaint to file. "*Yahan paani nahin hai.*" No water. It's a refrain one hears often, and drowns out any other talking point, though Jaimangal Gond, a denim-clad dhaba owner, is a fine piece of aware young citizenry. His range is wide: tribal politics elsewhere and the ironic powerlessness in being an Adivasi in UP—Jharkhand is right next door; dirt-poor villages straddling swank expressways; the airport planned at Myorpur (named for a Brit, a 'Muir'); the debate on the Constitution....

Brahmins and tribals sitting out of the races in an SC-reserved seat is natural. The anomaly is the Jatavs/ Chamars experiencing the same, an ironic legacy of the BSP's long dominance. In principle, it vouchsafes power to Dalits as a whole; in practice, it tends to be a Jatav-dominated party. "Historically, this started with the Congress patronising the more powerful Jatavs/ Chamars almost exclusively in its early decades. Jagjivan Ram was emblematic of that phase. When they cite 'Dalit' representation in the party, they usually mean Jatav/ Chamar even now," says Prof. K. Ravikant of Lucknow University. This, he says, was broken first by the BJP, "which meticulously picked up all non-Jatav castes in UP—Pasi, Kori, Valmiki etc.—and ensured representation at that end of the rainbow."



**ELITE CASTE ANGST**
**The Brahmin anger at the outgoing MP's caste abuse determined the NDA's choice of candidate. In Sehuan village, a group of Brahmins at the pradhan's house also voice frustration at the local 'Thakur raj'**

## Tokenism Rules

But all parties followed a path that eventually favoured a token form of representation. True national-level or even pan-Dalit leadership is now scantier than before—the lack of willingness among parties to field Dalits in general seats offers ironic proof. In both the 2004 and 2009 elections, for instance, the BJP and Congress combined gave only three tickets to Dalits from general seats. The Congress's early proprietary monopoly over Jatavs ended with the arrival of Kanshi Ram, and he came with an ambition to break precisely that barrier. Kanshi Ram contested from general seats like Allahabad (against V.P. Singh, 1988), Amethi (against Rajiv Gandhi, 1989) and, finally, successfully so from Etawah in 1991. But the subsequent phase of the BSP, dominated by Mayawati, "saw other promising leaders, even from non-Jatav Dalit castes, being systematically sidelined," says Prof. Ravikant.

The play of political control—whether by traditional parties or by subaltern ones run by "the new Dalit elite"—has created a paradoxical inversion of the democratic promise at all levels. In the political field, due to the leadership vacuum, the enervation continues in ever-new ways. "There is a new trend. Dominant caste people marrying Dalit women and fielding them as proxies in reserved seats. It's robbery of Dalit agency in broad daylight," says Sanjay Paswan, former Union minister who headed the BJP's SC Morcha during the Vajpayee years. "Chirag Paswan's Lok Janshakti Party has fielded one from Samastipur and Tejashwi Yadav's Rashtriya Janata Dal in Jamui." Shambhavi Choudhary, the Samastipur candidate, is the daughter of state minister Ashok Choudhury, but is married to a Bhumihar, the son of a prominent ex-IPS officer, who has been close to Chirag of late. In Jamui, the RJD candidate Archana Kumari is married to a Yadav. Examples of this are popping up even in assembly seats reserved for the SCs across states. Empowerment clearly continues to be a promise observed more in the breach. ■